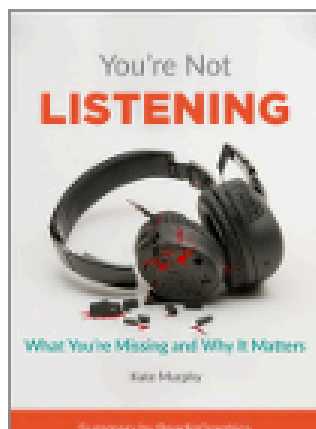




YOU'RE NOT LISTENING

What You're Missing and Why It Matters

Kate Murphy



The Big "So What"

In this book, Kate Murphy shares research, stories, and actionable tips, to show the importance of listening, why we often fail at it, and how we can become better listeners. This is not a technical how-to guide, but a book to transform how you see and connect with people around you.



Introduction



Good listening isn't inborn; it comes with practice. Anyone can learn to listen well, foster awareness, connection and understanding.

- Murphy's profession as a journalist requires her to listen to others, yet she felt her listening skills were not up to the mark. So, she spent 2 years researching the biomechanics and neurobiology of listening. Along the way, she interviewed accomplished individuals to learn how they define, perceive, and practice listening.
- This book captures her findings in 17 chapters with interconnected themes and ideas.



In this summary, we've distilled the insights into 2 key sections:

- What is listening and why it matters; and
- Mastering the art of genuine listening.

KEY QUOTES

"Listening is more of a mindset than a checklist of dos and don'ts."

"It is only by listening that we engage, understand, connect, empathize, and develop as human beings."



Part 1: What is Listening and Why It Matters



What is Listening and How it Works



Listening is an active, multisensory process where sound waves are received by our ears, interpreted by our brains, and further contextualized by visual and other non-verbal cues.

- Effective listening requires that you engage all your senses, setting aside your own agenda, biases, assumptions, and distractions.
- It involves a 2-way exchange where you open your mind, listen beyond words to discern emotional nuances, contexts, and intentions, and demonstrate your interest and understanding.
- Signs of bad listening include: interrupting, giving unrelated responses, appearing distracted, or fidgeting constantly.



The Neuroscience of Listening



Listening is a multisensory phenomenon, not an auditory one.

- When we listen to people, our brain processes not just the words, but also the pitch, tone, rhythm. Just consider the number of ways you can say the word "Sure".
- In a conversation, we interpret sounds along with other sensory cues. For example, lip-reading contributes up to 20% of our comprehension, and non-verbal cues (e.g. expressions and body language) carry >50% of a message.
 - (i) If you're not looking at someone when they speak, you'll miss a chunk of the message.
 - (ii) In remote communication, videos are better than voice calls, which are in turn better than texts or email.



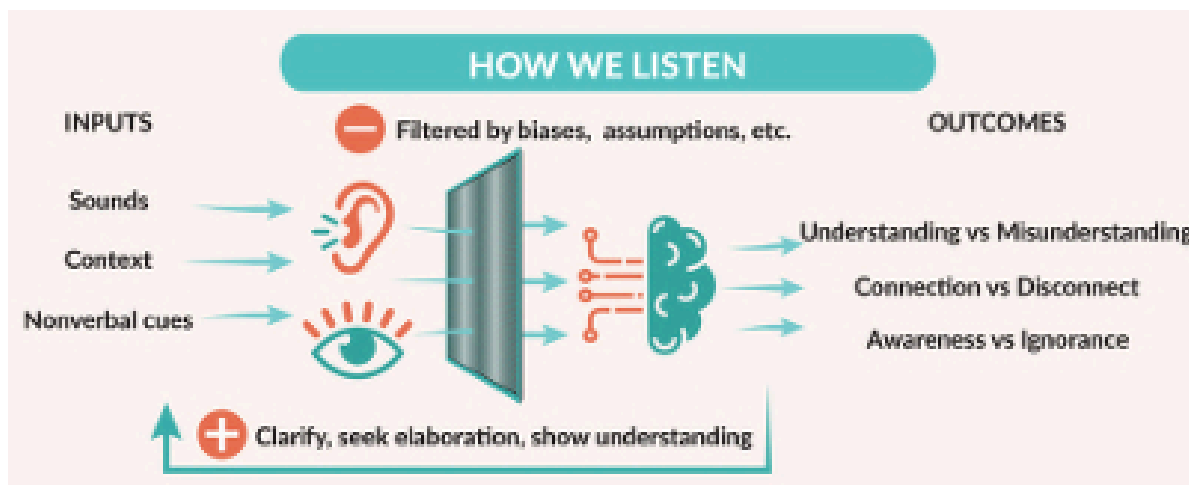
We use different parts of the brain depending on how we receive or interpret the message.

KEY QUOTES

"To really listen is to be moved physically, chemically, emotionally, and intellectually by another person's narrative."

"Listening is intricate and multisensory."

- Biases and prejudices literally block out parts of the message.
- Our brain also processes info differently depending on which ear receives it. Generally, the right ear is more attuned to emotions while the left ear is more attuned to facts and language. If someone tilts their right ear towards the source, they're probably subconsciously trying to focus on the speaker's emotional intent.



 The attachment theory suggests that our ability to listen and connect is shaped during early childhood.

- Children with attentive caregivers are likely to grow up to become more empathetic listeners, while those with inattentive caregivers may struggle with genuine connections later in life.
- The good news is, you can develop healthy listening habits as an adult, regardless of your childhood experiences. All it takes is awareness and effort.



Why Listening Is Important



Listening is essential for building meaningful relationships. Without listening, we cannot understand other human beings.

- At a personal level, it affects our ability to be a good friend, parent, or partner.
- At a professional level, it affects our ability to understand our colleagues, serve our customers, or sell anything.



Listening is also essential for learning and personal growth. Through listening, we learn about others and ourselves. A keen listener can often help others to articulate the thoughts/

KEY QUOTES

"Evolution gave us eyelids so we can close our eyes but no corresponding structure to close off our ears. It suggests listening is essential to our survival."

"To listen poorly, selectively, or not at all is to limit your understanding of the world and deprive yourself of becoming the best you can be."

"People get lonely for lack of listening."

feelings they hadn't been able to express themselves. When someone listens intently to you, it also encourages you to listen deeply to yourself.



Real listening and connection (or a lack thereof) have tangible effects on our physical, mental and emotional well-being. Active listening combats feelings of loneliness and isolation, which are linked to a host of health issues like heart disease, dementia, depression, and anxiety.



A lack of real listening amplifies conflict and misunderstandings, hurts relationships, and contributes to our current epidemic of loneliness and disconnect.

- We live in a digital age where people appear more “connected” via technology. In reality, the opposite is true—people are feeling more detached and isolated. After interviewing people from diverse backgrounds, Murphy found that most people feel unheard. Many are resorting to professional services like counseling or coaching just to find someone who will listen attentively to them.
- Research suggests a direct correlation between unhappiness and screen time. This could explain why Generation Z is more likely to feel lonely, isolated, and even suicidal, compared to older generations.
- According to the World Health Organization, suicide rates have increased 45% globally in the past decade, with depression and the lack of meaningful connections as key contributors.



Online options like social media do not create real connections.

- In online communities, the vast majority of users are passive. Only 1% of participants contribute to the bulk of the content, creating a skewed picture of what people truly feel or believe.
- About 15–60% of social media accounts are either fake or created by bots. This means that a large chunk of social media interactions are not even from human beings.
- The most active users are not truly interested in two-way communication. They usually aim to broadcast their messages, seek validation, or gain followers/likes/shares. Social media content also tends to be either unrealistically positive or excessively negative.

KEY QUOTES

“Truly listening to someone is a skill many seem to have forgotten or perhaps never learned in the first place.”

“We are too busy, or too distracted, to explore the depths of one another’s thoughts and feelings.”



Part 2: Mastering the Art of Genuine Listening

In this section, we'll address the barriers to listening and how to overcome them to become a great listener.



Avoid The Assumption Trap



Assumptions and biases can block communication and understanding.

- We unconsciously use social signals and stereotypes to make snap judgments about others. We may gauge others' social status based on the clothes they wear, the schools they attend, the cars they drive, etc.
 - (i) Knowing someone's biography or persona (e.g. vegan, democrat) isn't the same as understanding them as a person.
 - (ii) Brain scans show that labels and stereotypes can shut down parts of our brain and filter out information that don't fit our preconceptions.
- People in intimate relationships (e.g. married couples, parent-child) often suffer from the "closeness-communication bias". They over-estimate how well they can predict the other person's thoughts and feelings, leading to miscommunication. In reality, studies show that partners in a relationship may not understand each other better than strangers.
- Misunderstandings usually occur because we assume people think like us, when they don't. Even if you share the same native language, you might interpret the same words or expressions differently, e.g. the word "original" could mean different things to 2 individuals. The potential for misunderstanding multiplies once you add in differing native languages, backgrounds, and personal values/beliefs.



Remember: you can never truly know someone else's mind.

- Evolutionary psychologist Robin Dunbar suggested that we can only manage up to 150 meaningful relationships at a time (Dunbar's Rule). Within these, only a handful are deeply

KEY QUOTES

"It's all too easy to get complacent about how well you know those closest to you, just as it's hard not to make assumptions about strangers based on stereotypes."

"No matter how well we try to listen, or how close we feel to another person, it's important to remember we can never really know another person's mind."

It's perfectly fine to say "I need some time to process this" or "I'm not sure what to say."



Manage Distractions



Today, many of us are addicted to our digital devices, such that we're exhibiting similar patterns as substance abuse.

- We compulsively reach for our phones whenever we feel bored, or even when we're in the middle of a social engagement. We impatiently switch between tasks, messages, and media channels, and abandon a website if it takes just a few seconds to load.
- Our attention can be further diluted by ambient distractions, such as open office setups, noisy restaurants, or the hum of the TV.



A diminished attention span has serious implications.

- We may get so habitually distracted that we can no longer concentrate deeply on any task, or even think deeply. This impedes creativity and deep work.
- Our listening faculties also suffer. During conversations, our eyes and minds wander habitually. The mere presence of a phone on the table (even if it's silenced) can cause a sense of disconnectedness, leading to dull and unfulfilling conversations, which in turn increases the chance of our attention drifting.



Pick a quiet, distraction-free environment for your conversations. This signals your commitment to listen, and allows you to focus fully on the interaction. Even the simple act of having device-free meals as a family has been found to improve connection.



Listen for Nuances and Underlying Messages



Listening is more than hearing the words or literal content of what's being said. Good communicators exhibit "conversational sensitivity" to detect emotional undertones, nuances, and hidden meanings.

KEY QUOTES

"Device dependency has many of the same behavioral, psychological, and neurobiological components as substance abuse."

"It's hard to concentrate on what's happening in the real world when you're preoccupied with what could be happening in the virtual one."

KEY QUOTES

"Intuition...is nothing more than recognition. The more people you listen to, the more aspects of humanity you will recognize, and the better your gut instinct will be."

"Everybody is interesting if you ask the right questions. If someone is dull or uninteresting, it's on you."

"It takes awareness, focus, and experience to unearth and understand what is really being communicated."

"Inner dialogue fosters and supports cognitive complexity, that valuable ability to tolerate a range of views, make associations, and come up with new ideas."

- This is not an inborn talent, but a skill that comes from practice and listening to lots of people. Good listeners can discern verbal and nonverbal cues to figure out: "Why are they telling me this?"
- Retired hostage negotiator Gary Noesner says that the key to successful negotiations is simply to listen and respond empathically. Often, hostage-takers and mass-shooters are just people who feel extremely depressed and alienated. Once they feel heard and understood, even the tensest situations can be de-escalated.

 Pay attention to every detail. For example, the radio show *Fresh Air* enlists 3 producers just to review and dissect each interview, and properly capture every nuance and detail.

- You can do some homework in advance to learn about them, or ask questions to understand where they're coming from.
- If something seems off, seek clarification by saying something like: "I was confused about what you said about X. Can you elaborate?"
- The best con artists can hone in on their victims' hopes and fears not because they're talented listeners, but because they're more motivated to listen well. Conversely, people get deceived because they don't listen carefully enough. It all boils down to motivation and practice.



Support (not Shift) the Conversation

 Keep the attention on the speaker, instead of redirecting the conversation to yourself.

- According to sociologist Charles Derber, we can respond to others in 2 ways:
 - (i) *Support responses* focus on the speaker, validating their feelings or experiences, and encouraging them to elaborate.
 - (ii) *Shifting responses* redirect the conversation away from the speaker to the listener. This may be done out of self-centeredness, or to avoid discomfort.

 Embrace uncertainties and complexities. Accept that you might be wrong—or at least not completely right.

- Instead of seeing things in absolutes or black-and-white, learn to accept conflicting ideas and shades of gray. By embracing and connecting diverse viewpoints, you open up new ways of thinking, to bring fresh insights and creative solutions.
- You can listen with an open mind without agreeing with the other person. Often, there are multiple truths leading to a larger truth—the more perspectives you consider, the more robust your understanding.



Listen to the Pauses and Silences

 Most people feel uneasy with silences during conversations. Often, we rush to fill the gap, or start talking before the other person has finished speaking.

- Generally, people tend to be more comfortable with long silences if they feel secure about themselves or their relationships.
- There are also cultural differences around silence. In some cultures (e.g. in Japan or Finland), it's a sign of respect and consideration to pause before responding.



Silence can convey much more than words.

- Good listeners wait patiently and read the pauses and silences. By keeping quiet, they also encourage others to share more information, which can be an advantage in sales or negotiations.
- Give people the time/space to gather their thoughts or feelings, consider their response, or make a decision. You'll end up gathering better information while avoiding impulsive comments you might regret.



Practice intentional silence to cultivate patience and awareness.

- Try being silent for 24 hours. You'll probably find yourself becoming more aware of the sounds and subtle cues around you (which you'd have missed if you were talking).

KEY QUOTES

"We only become secure in our convictions by allowing them to be challenged."

"To listen does not mean, or even imply, that you agree with someone... Good listeners know understanding is not binary."

"Resisting the urge to jump in makes it more likely you will leave conversations with additional insight and greater understanding."

"To be a good listener is to accept pauses and silences."

"You get so much more out of interactions when you allow people the time and space to gather their thoughts."

facilitator may interrupt anyone mid-sentence and ask someone else to pick up the thread, forcing people to pay close attention.

- (ii) Or, members may be asked to mimic their partner's words, expressions and movements. This requires them to connect deeply and sync up physically and mentally.
- During such sessions, it's common for people to show off, hold back, or disrupt the process. Instead of chastising such behaviors, use the chance to uncover underlying issues that are blocking listening and collaboration, such as insecurities, the fear of being vulnerable, or the need for control.



Listen to your Inner Voice



Listening to yourself is as important as listening to others.

- We talk to ourselves all the time. We judge, analyze, scold/praise ourselves, and hold internal arguments. Our inner voices are so impactful because they seem louder than external voices.
- Our internal dialogues often mirror the external voices we're exposed to. Our thoughts and perspectives tend to reflect those of friends, family members, or media personalities. These in turn affect how we interact with others. For example, if you're used to blaming and criticizing yourself, you're more likely to blame and criticize others.



Pay attention to your inner tone and messages:

- Replace the voice of a critical parent or negative friend with the voice of a nurturing counsellor or a respected coach.
- Read widely and listen to a diverse range of people to broaden your perspectives, enrich your inner dialogues and cognitive capabilities.



Listening in Gossip and Research



Gossip is often viewed negatively. However, when done with a discerning ear, it can be a useful social tool.

KEY QUOTES

"Connectedness is necessarily a two-way street, each partner in the conversation listening and latching on to what the other said."

"How you talk to yourself affects how you hear other people... our inner dialogue influences and distorts what other people say and thus how we behave in relationships."

- Much like how apes groom each other for social bonding, humans use gossip for social bonding and learning. Through gossip, we learn about group dynamics and social norms/values. By talking about shared acquaintances/events, we learn from others' experiences, and figure out what behaviors are rewarded or rejected by others.
- The key is to listen attentively to discern nuances and detect false or malicious information.



In an era of Big Data—where the focus is increasingly on numbers and statistics—we still need keen listening and qualitative data.

- Quantitative data can give us a broad picture, but it cannot explain human emotions, preferences, habits, or motivations. Moreover, you can't build sound statistical models or algorithms without understanding the issues/people being represented by the data. To explain the "why" behind the "what", we still need qualitative research.
- For example, Betty Crocker's cake mix wasn't selling well even though it was so easy to use—you just had to add water. Qualitative research found that homemakers felt guilty using the cake mix because it was too effortless. Once the formula was tweaked to require home-cooks to add water and crack in some eggs, sales increased significantly.
- Good qualitative research draws out people's real thoughts, inclinations, and emotions. This in turn requires active listening and neutrality on the part of the researcher.



Know When to Stop Listening



Active listening can be mentally and emotionally taxing. It's not sustainable all the time, even for close relationships. Good listeners consciously choose when to listen and when not to.

- If you're feeling too exhausted or distressed to listen, it may be better to stop the conversation and resume when you're in a better condition to listen and connect.

KEY QUOTES

"Listening...is not only how we learn to be virtuous members of society, it is in itself a virtue that makes us worthy of the most valuable information."

"Even in the era of abundant data, we need to listen to get to understanding."

"Information is only as useful as how it's collected and interpreted."

"You get to decide how much effort you want to put in and when you've had enough."

"Listening is your gift to bestow. No one can make you listen."

- It may also be better to stop listening if you truly cannot get on the same wavelength as the other party. This could be due to a lack of reciprocity, circular conversations that go nowhere, or toxic/abusive relationships.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

How well or badly you listen can decide whether you end up with understanding or misunderstanding, strengthening or hurting a relationship. The book is packed with research references and anecdotes of Murphy's interactions with writers, researchers, show producers, psychologists, hostage negotiator, coaches, and other personalities. For more information, please visit www.journalistkatemurphy.com.



About the Author

Kate Murphy is a Texas-based journalist whose has written for The New York Times, The Economist, Agence France-Presse, and Texas Monthly. She covers a wide range of topics including health, technology, science, design, art, aviation, business, finance, fashion, dining, travel, real estate, and is best known for her work on the science behind human interactions.



KEY QUOTES